



OFF-SIDE

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THE LAST PAGES OF A LOVE AFFAIR

To have **lived in the age of Messi** was a privilege. To have covered it as a journalist was an outrageous piece of good fortune.

My first glimpse of Lionel Messi in the flesh came in 2011, when Argentina travelled to Kolkata to play Venezuela in an international friendly. It was his first match as captain of the Albiceleste and, in the baking humidity of a Kolkata evening, through a stop-start game that rarely found a rhythm worthy of its principal attraction, Messi offered his Bengali faithful fleeting glimpses of the magic that would turn many of them into cult worshippers for years to come.

Thousands of miles from Rosario, where he was born, and Barcelona, where his football education took shape, Messi had somehow acquired another footballing home. In this eastern corner of India, and across the border in Bangladesh, a legion already existed for whom Argentina's blue and white was almost a second national colour.

West Bengal, fresh then with a new government at the helm, much as it is today, did not cover itself in glory that evening. The stadium lights went out during the Argentina captain's post-match press conference, hijacked by an assortment of "influentials" desperate for proximity to Messi, much like his ill-fated recent return to the City of Joy.

Seven years later, at my first World Cup in Russia, I saw a very different Messi.

Under Jorge Sampaoli, he seemed to carry the weight of an entire country's unfulfilled expectations. By then, he had won almost everything football could offer, but the one absence had become larger than everything else he possessed. The World Cup was the line that, unfairly or otherwise, separated his greatness from the divinity Argentina and the world had bestowed upon Diego Maradona.

Argentina in Russia was a team without equilibrium,

and France ruthlessly sent it home in Kazan, propelled by a young Kylian Mbappe who appeared to be announcing the arrival of football's next age. We were left once more to contemplate how a dysfunctional system had failed to extract the best from an extraordinary footballer.

There had been heartbreaks already. The lost World Cup and Copa America finals, the brief international retirement, the endless debate about whether Messi could ever reproduce in an Argentina shirt what came so effortlessly at Barcelona. The personal awards and club trophies kept accumulating, but the missing piece grew heavier with every passing year.

The appointment of Lionel Scaloni as the national coach was supposed to be temporary, an administrative bridge while Argentina searched for something grander. Instead, Messi's former international teammate helped construct the environment Messi had spent much of his international career searching for.

The first senior international triumph arrived at the Copa America in 2021. Then came Qatar.

But even there, destiny initially appeared determined to torment him. Argentina lost its opening match to Saudi Arabia, one of the great World Cup shocks, and the familiar image returned of a despondent Messi and a bewildered Argentina. In the stadium, journalists like us were quick to reach for an old explanation. Perhaps Argentina had still not learned how to get the best out of him.

But we were wrong. This was a different Messi. And around him were men prepared to fight, scrap and bleed for their captain.

Messi, too, had discarded some of the old niceties. He argued, snarled and confronted. He could brawl when Argentina needed a brawler and still produce beauty when the game demanded an artist. The shy genius had